



The People of West Asia

RELIGION HAS ALWAYS exerted an enormous influence on this part of the world. Islam—which originated in the Middle East and spread rapidly to both north Africa and western and central Asia—is an important force. Hinduism, and to a lesser extent, Buddhism, both of which developed farther south, are also very much alive here.

MECCA

One of the Five Pillars of Islam is the *hajj* (pilgrimage to Mecca). Devout Muslims, like the people on these buses, dream of making this journey at least once in their lives. Mecca was the birthplace of Islam's founding prophet, Mohammed, and the place where he first preached his faith.



TRADITION AND MODERNITY

This bride preparing for her wedding wears a white bridal gown similar to those worn in the West. People worldwide are being exposed to foreign practices, some of which they take on, adapt, and even incorporate into their own traditions.

Most Muslim girls and women cover their hair.

DUBAI

One of the Gulf States, the United Arab Emirates has enjoyed great prosperity thanks to its precious natural resource—oil. Dubai, one of its main cities, is a wonder of both traditional Arab and ultramodern architecture.

